

## (GAME NAME) — Baseline Rules

*Version: 2026-05-19. Source of truth for all test scenario rule sheets.*

*Do not edit this file during a playtest — use the layer-specific rule sheet instead.*

---

### Introduction

**(GAME NAME)** is a 2-player abstract-tactical board game. There is no luck — no dice, no hidden information. Every decision is made with full knowledge of the board.

**What you command:** Each player leads an army of Guards and Champions, all serving a King. Guards are fast, Champions carry powerful skills. Your King is the most important piece on the board — and the target.

**How you win:** Capture the opponent's King. The game ends immediately when a King is removed.

**How a game flows:** Players alternate turns. On your turn you first move your pieces (and attack), then activate skills. Piece capture, skill combos, and board control build toward the moment you threaten — and take — the enemy King.

**What makes it deep:** Skills cost Runes. Runes are scarce. You will always want to do more than you can. That tension — between movement, attacks, and skill combos — is the game.

---

### Simple Overview

*A surface-level map of every system. No edge cases — just what each thing does.*

**Rounds and turns:** The game is played in Rounds. Each Round, P1 takes a full turn, then P2. A turn has two phases: Movement Phase, then Action Phase.

**Movement Phase:** You have 2 Move Slots. Spend one to move a piece up to its speed. Each piece can only be moved once per phase.

**Standard Attack:** Instead of moving, spend a Move Slot to move your piece onto an enemy tile. The enemy takes 1 DMG.

**Health:** Every piece has 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. Taking 1 DMG moves a piece one step along that track. Injured pieces are slower and have shorter skill range.

**Armor:** A piece can hold up to 3 Armor. Each point absorbs 1 incoming DMG **before** HP is affected, then is destroyed.

**Action Phase:** You have Skill Slots (starting at 2 per turn). Spend one Skill Slot + Runes to activate an equipped skill on one of your Champions or King.

**Runes:** Your currency. You earn them automatically each turn (starting at +2/turn, scaling up over time). Skills cost Runes.

**Skills and Skill Path:** Skills travel in a straight line from the caster (like a chess Queen). That path is blocked by any piece in the way. Most skills have a default range of 2 tiles.

**Bodyguard:** When a Champion or King is attacked (with a standard attack), you can choose to have an adjacent Guard take the hit instead.

**Skill Drafting:** Before the game, players alternate picking skills from a shared pool and assigning them to their Champions and King. Each piece gets 2 skills.

**Progression:** As the game goes on, your Rune income and number of Skill Slots per turn both grow — late-game turns are more powerful because you can cast more skills.

*For full rules and edge cases, read the sections below.*

---

## Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

### Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

---

## Components

**Per player:** 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

**Shared (Prototype):** 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

---

## Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

---

## Setup

- **Board:** Use the 10x10 grid.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
  - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
  - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Runes:** Each player starts with **6 Runes**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

---

## Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Rune income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Runes and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

---

## Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Movement Phase** — spend Move Slots to move pieces (and attack).
- **Action Phase** — spend Skill Slots to activate skills.

You may use 0 slots in either phase.

---

## Movement Phase

You have **2 Move Slots** per turn. Spend 1 Move Slot to move one piece. **Each piece may only be moved once per Movement Phase.**

| Piece           | Normal speed | Injured speed |
|-----------------|--------------|---------------|
| Guard           | 2 tiles      | 1 tile        |
| Champion / King | 1 tile       | 1 tile        |

**Free pathing:** A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

**Pieces block movement:** A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).

---

## Standard Attack

To attack, spend a Move Slot to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 DMG** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile.
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece stops on the tile immediately before the target. *(If there are multiple paths toward the target then you are allowed to choose which one you want to take (important for Bodyguard Rule))*

You may attack with one Move Slot and move a different piece with the other Move Slot in the same turn.

---

## Bodyguard Rule

When you make a **Standard Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if a friendly Guard is on a tile adjacent to both the tile immediately before the target (along the attack path) and the defending piece.**

### Interception:

- Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
- The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
- The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the target).

**Interception is optional.** The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible and can select which guard should take the damage if multiple Guards are eligible.

Only Standard Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

---

## Action Phase

You have **2 Skill Slots** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 Skill Slot to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Rune cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have Skill Slots remaining.

---

## Skill System

**Skill Path:** Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

**Blocking:** The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

**Range:** The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

**Default Range = 2.** Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

**Self vs. adjacent:** “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus Strike) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

**Injured Range penalty:** Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

**Skills that move pieces do not deal damage.** Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

**A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn** if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

---

## Resource Economy (Runes)

**Starting Runes:** 6 per player.

Rune income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn:**

| Round | Income per player turn  |
|-------|-------------------------|
| 1     | 0 (starting Runes only) |
| 2-4   | +2                      |
| 5-9   | +3                      |
| 10-14 | +4                      |
| 15+   | +5 (+1 every 5 rounds)  |

**No Rune cap.**

---

## Progression

| Round | Skill Slots per turn   |
|-------|------------------------|
| 1-10  | 2                      |
| 11-20 | 3                      |
| 21-30 | 4                      |
| 31+   | 5 (+1 every 10 rounds) |

---

## Health & Armor

**All pieces have 2 HP:** Normal → Injured → Removed.

| State   | HP | Effect                                                     |
|---------|----|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Normal  | 2  | No penalty                                                 |
| Injured | 1  | Speed capped at 1. Skill Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only). |
| Removed | 0  | Piece leaves the board permanently.                        |

### Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

**Armor:** Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

## Skill Reference

|                                                                                     | Cat.   | Name             | Cost | Effect                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | Strike | Lance Thrust     | 2    | Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|    | Strike | Hook Pull        | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|    | Strike | Armor Breaker    | 2    | Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Blade Call)</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|    | Strike | Rune Theft       | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|    | Strike | Blade Tempest    | 4    | Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|    | Shield | Rust Shield      | 2    | Self: gain +1 Armor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|    | Shield | Field Medic      | 3    | Remove Injured from one adjacent ally                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|    | Shield | Armorsmith       | 3    | Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|    | Move   | Quick Dash       | 3    | Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|    | Move   | Air Blast        | 2    | Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|    | Move   | Precision Thrust | 3    | Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|    | Move   | Shadow Shift     | 4    | Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|   | Move   | Retreat Plan     | 4    | Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. <b>Range+1.</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|  | Mystic | Focus Strike     | 1    | The next skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> <b>Move skills:</b> the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its <b>activation range</b> (how far the skill can target) or its <b>effect range</b> (how far it moves/pushes). Not both. |
|  | Mystic | Blade Call       | 3    | One Strike skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn deals +1 DMG.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## Quick Reference

| Concept               | Rule                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Movement              | Free pathing, $\leq$ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per Movement Phase.                                                                           |
| Guard speed           | Normal: 2 tiles. Injured: 1 tile.                                                                                                                                              |
| Champion / King speed | 1 tile (Normal or Injured).                                                                                                                                                    |
| Standard Attack       | Move onto enemy tile (1 Move Slot). Deals <b>1 DMG</b> . Attacker stops before target if target survives.                                                                      |
| Skill Path            | Straight line (Queen-style). Blocked by <b>all</b> pieces — ally and enemy.                                                                                                    |
| Skill Range           | Default Range 2. Skills with “self” = Range 0. Skills with “adjacent” = Range 1. Range modifiers (e.g. Range-1) apply from default.                                            |
| Injured Range penalty | Injured pieces: Skill Range -1. Does not affect “self” or “adjacent” skills.                                                                                                   |
| Bodyguard             | Standard Attacks on Champion/King only. Guard must be adjacent to both tile-before-target AND defender. Guard takes the hit. Defender chooses which eligible Guard intercepts. |
| Armor                 | Max 3 per piece. Each point absorbs 1 DMG before HP, then is destroyed. Does not prevent Injured status.                                                                       |
| Health                | 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. 1 DMG = one step. 2 DMG = skip Injured, Removed instantly.                                                                                   |
| Rune income           | Collected at start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). Starts 6, then +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.                                                                                             |
| Skill Slots           | Start at 2/turn. Grow with Progression (Rounds 1–10: 2, 11–20: 3, 21–30: 4, 31+: 5).                                                                                           |
| Focus Strike          | +1 Range to next skill this turn. Can boost self (→ adjacent) and adjacent (→ Range 2) skills. On Move skills, caster chooses: activation range OR effect range.               |
| Blade Call            | +1 DMG to one Strike skill this turn. Stacks with Combo Bonus.                                                                                                                 |